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Urban Indian Private Schools at Risk of Proximity to Toxic Lead Sites: Report

Urban Indian private schools at risk of proximity to toxic lead sites: report

A study has found that 90% of private schools in New Delhi are located near a site contaminated with lead, mercury, arsenic, and/or pesticides; as opposed to developed countries, the study found that in low- and middle-income countries, urban schools are 4- to 28-times more likely than rural schools to be near a toxic site

Monika Mondal
NEW DELHI

In high-income countries like the U.S. and the U.K., it is well-established that people who live in poorer and marginalised localities are more exposed to pollution than those in wealthier neighbourhoods. According to a recent report, that pattern seems to be reversed in low- and middle-income countries (LMIC) like India.

A report, titled 'Schools in the Shadow of Toxic Sites: Pollution Proximity in Low- and Middle-Income Countries', by the Center for Global Development (CGD) looked at how close 2,840 schools were to toxic sites in 17 countries. It concluded that 10% of schools in LMICs lie within 5 km of a documented toxic site, especially in urban areas.

And of all the world's capital cities, New Delhi topped the list, with more than 80% of its private schools located near a site contaminated with lead, mercury, cadmium, arsenic, and/or pesticides.

When exposed to such contaminants, children in particular develop higher risk of heart and kidney diseases as well as of irreversible learning and cognitive disabilities. According to the World Bank, lead exposure during childhood alone costs LMICs \$1 trillion a year.

'Equally exposed to contamination'
While lead exists naturally in the deep layers of the earth, no amount of lead exposure is safe for humans. Once it enters the body, it can stay silently stuck to the bones, mimicking calcium. When mixed with blood, it can lead to severe kidney and heart problems. In individuals showing no acute symptoms, it can spike blood pressure and lead to sudden heart attacks.

Among children, lead can be a powerful neurotoxin that degrades myelin, the protective outer layer of the brain, and hampers brain cell connections.

In the last few decades, more and more studies from both developed and developing countries have linked lead exposure to shortened attention spans, heightened aggression, behavioural disorders, and a permanent drop in IQ.

"But we did not know where exactly the problem was," Lee Crawford, the report's author and a researcher at the CGD, London.

For the analysis, Mr. Crawford mapped 2.6 million schools to 11,301 documented toxic sites across Mexico, India, Ghana, Kenya, Armenia, and 12 other countries. While the contamination was severe within a few metres of a site, pollutants do not remain there forever. People living as far as 5 km from a toxic site have shown to have elevated blood lead levels as well. "If you look at household lead



Stripping scrapped laptops and air conditioners for metal frequently involves burning away rubber wire casings, releasing lead, mercury, and cadmium into the air. When exposed to such contaminants, children develop higher risk of heart and kidney diseases as well as of cognitive disabilities. AP

exposure, the poorest are slightly more likely to be exposed than the richest, but since lead exposure can be impactful within 5 km of radius, everyone who lives and breathes in the same air is equally exposed to the contamination," Mr. Crawford said.

The study found 9.7% of schools in the sample were within 5 km of a contaminated site. As a result, "Nearly a billion children have some lead exposure globally. And we know that a big share of that comes from polluted sites, many of them lead-battery recycling," Mr. Crawford said.

As opposed to developed countries, where polluting sites lie where public opposition is weakest, the study found that in LMICs, urban schools are 4- to 28-times more likely than rural schools to be near a toxic site. "The results are a bit surprising," Mr. Crawford said.

"But it makes sense with the urban clustering. If you don't have good regulation of where recycling can happen, then it happens in the most convenient places, which is where people are."

Paradox of development, recycling
Lead-acid batteries are used to start most petrol and diesel motor engines; lead is also present in smaller quantities in the electrical components of photovoltaic

cells, wind turbines, and as part of back-up power supply systems. These batteries alone contribute to 86% of global lead consumption.

Lead acid batteries are also popular because they are cheap, rechargeable, and easy to recycle. The metal melts at 327°C, a temperature that can be achieved using a blowtorch in a backyard. Thus, numerous informal enterprises have erupted in India that simply break open old batteries, isolate the lead-containing parts, and toss them in a furnace. The liquid lead is then filtered out and recast into ingots for new batteries.

But without a safe, closed-loop management system, the lead leeches into the soil and can enter human bodies through food, water, and the air.

In developed countries, lead is generally recycled under strict guidelines and with restrictions, and costs tens of millions of dollars. But in LMICs, where enforcement is weak and labour is cheap, a large proportion of recycling happens in backyards.

Thus, in India, even though there are more than 350 well-equipped recycling units, some 90% of the waste ends up in the informal network, where profits are also higher.

As per the report, this network is now

estimated to be responsible for around 33% of the world's lead poisoning burden. In LMICs, this burden is equivalent to 80 lakh disability-adjusted life years or 8 lakh annual deaths.

'An invisible problem'

Mr. Crawford said variables like a school being private, secondary or single-sex all correlated to some degree with higher pollution exposure simply because they were clustered in cities. New Delhi had 91.2% of schools within 5 km of a toxic site; it was followed by Manila (88%), Nairobi (71%), Accra (67%), and Jakarta (51%). This clustering is not inevitable, however: Mr. Crawford's analysis also found that Mexico City, despite its large size and high population density, had almost no toxic-site contamination because its industrial manufacturing zones were successfully regulated and separated from the urban core.

"Lead is an invisible problem that's easy to ignore," Mr. Crawford said. "But a badly polluted site can be regulated, closed down or moved out of city/populated areas. It's something that the Indian government has done and they can do it, with more public pressure."

(Monika Mondal is a freelance science and environment journalist. a.monikamondal@gmail.com)

THE GIST

While lead exists naturally in the deep layers of the earth, no amount of lead exposure is safe for humans

When mixed with blood, it can lead to severe kidney and heart problems. In individuals showing no acute symptoms, it can spike blood pressure and lead to sudden heart attacks

In children, lead can be a powerful neurotoxin that degrades myelin, the protective outer layer of the brain, and hampers brain cell connections

Urban Indian Private Schools at Risk of Proximity to Toxic Lead Sites: Report

● The Study

○ In high-income countries like the US and UK, poorer localities are more exposed to pollution than wealthier ones; that pattern seems reversed in low- and middle-income countries like India, where lead exposure is impactful enough within a 5 km radius that everyone nearby is equally exposed

● Health Impact

○ While lead exists naturally in the deep layers of the earth, no amount of lead exposure is safe for humans; once it enters the body it can stay silently stuck to the bones, mimicking calcium

○ When mixed with blood, it can lead to severe kidney and heart problems and can spike blood pressure leading to sudden heart attacks; among children, lead is a powerful neurotoxin that degrades myelin and hampers brain cell connections, linked to shortened attention spans and a permanent drop in IQ

● The Paradox of Development and Recycling

○ Lead-acid batteries, used in most petrol and diesel motor engines, solar cells, wind turbines, and back-up power systems, contribute 86% of global lead consumption; they are popular because they are cheap, rechargeable, and easy to recycle, melting at 327°C, achievable with a backyard blowtorch

○ In developed countries, lead is recycled under strict guidelines at high cost; but in low- and middle-income countries, where enforcement is weak and labour is cheap, a large proportion of recycling happens in backyards; in India, even though there are more than 350 well-equipped recycling units, some 90% of the waste ends up in the informal network, where profits are higher

● The Way Forward

○ Mexico City, despite its large size, had almost no toxic-site contamination because its industrial manufacturing zones were successfully regulated and separated from the urban core

Urban Indian Private Schools at Risk of Proximity to Toxic Lead Sites: Report

- Lead is a toxic, naturally occurring heavy metal characterized by its softness, malleability, and bluish-white luster, with no safe level of exposure identified.
- WHO identifies lead as one of 10 chemicals of major public health concern. (Plumbism and Saturism)
- Lead-based paint continues to be a major global source of lead exposure.
- WHO and UNEP's Global Alliance to Eliminate Lead Paint urges countries to implement legal restrictions;

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Occupational Sources

- Battery manufacturing and recycling
- Mining and smelting
- Glass and ceramic industries
- Automobile repair
- Painting and printing
- Pottery and plumbing
- Soldering and lead pipe/plastic manufacturing

Non-Occupational Sources (Everyday Exposure):

- Traditional medicines
- Contaminated cosmetics and spices
- Household paints and storage batteries
- Vehicular emissions
- Industrial effluents contaminating soil, water, and dust
- Food grown in contaminated areas
- Food cooked or stored in lead-coated utensils
- Painted toys
- Retained bullet fragments

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Q. Lead, ingested or inhaled, is a health hazard. After the addition of lead to petrol has been banned, what still are the sources of lead poisoning? (2012)

1. Smelting units
2. Pens and pencils
3. Paints
4. Hair oils and cosmetics

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 2 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

Co-existing with tigers outside reserves

India's tiger conservation story is widely regarded as one of the world's most extraordinary wildlife recoveries – a species brought back from near extinction through sustained political commitment, scientific management, and decades of on-ground protection. Since the launch of Project Tiger in 1973, the country's network of protected areas has expanded from nine reserves covering 18,278 sq km to 58 reserves spanning 84,488 sq km, accounting for nearly 2.6% of India's landmass. India's tiger population has risen from 1,411 in 2006 to 3,682 in 2022, firmly establishing the country as home to over 70% of the world's wild tigers. This success has now created a new conservation frontier – the growing proportion of tigers living outside protected areas.

Although national datasets do not conclusively link rising tiger numbers with increasing human-tiger conflict, forest departments across several landscapes report a steady escalation in such incidents. As territorial carnivores require extensive home ranges, tigers disperse naturally when core habitats reach saturation. Consequently, more tigers are moving beyond protected boundaries into human-dominated fringes. According to the National Tiger Conservation Authority, 35-40% of India's tiger population now lives outside designated Tiger Reserves. This reality has prompted the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change to launch the **Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves (TOTR)** initiative.

Beyond protected boundaries
The growing tiger population reflects healthy breeding groups, functional habitats, and well-connected forest corridors. However, when tigers move beyond protected areas into landscapes interwoven with villages, farms, roads and other human infrastructure, interactions



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The objective of the **Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves** initiative is to establish a scientifically grounded, landscape-based framework for conserving tigers outside protected areas while safeguarding human lives

with people become inevitable, leading to human fatalities, livestock depredation, accidental encounters, prolonged rescue operations, and heightened public anxiety. Each incident carries ecological, social, and political consequences, placing enormous pressure on forest departments and district administrations.

The objective of the TOTR is to establish a scientifically grounded, landscape-based framework for conserving tigers outside protected areas while safeguarding human lives and livelihoods. Rather than responding to conflict only after it occurs, the initiative seeks to shift the approach from reactive crisis management to proactive, science-driven governance built on technology, preparedness, and community participation.

The TOTR is being launched as a targeted pilot rather than a nationwide rollout, recognising that long-term policy must be anchored in evidence generated under real field conditions.

The All-India Tiger Estimation (2022) recorded tiger presence across 212 forest divisions. Based on this assessment, 40 forest divisions across nine States have been selected for the first phase of the TOTR implementation. The participating States include Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Assam.

The TOTR rests on two complementary pillars. The first focuses on reducing human-tiger conflict and strengthening field protection. This includes upgrading communication systems, deploying rapid response teams, improving rescue infrastructure, and ensuring coordinated action during emergencies. The second pillar emphasises long-term coexistence. Conservation outside protected areas cannot succeed without the trust and participation of local communities. Awareness programmes, community engagement, timely compensation

and treating villagers as partners are central to the initiative. Tigers and people now co-occur across vast shared landscapes, making structured coexistence essential for long-term stability.

Among these, streamlined and timely compensation mechanisms are critical. Although States have their own frameworks, delays often erode public trust and fuel resentment. States must simplify procedures and invest in sustained outreach to build confidence among rural families living alongside tigers.

The role of States

Participating States will also need to invest strategically in both technology and institutional capacity. The programme rightly emphasises the use of modern conservation tools such as camera traps, GPS-enabled monitoring systems, drones and AI to strengthen surveillance, improve early warning systems and enable evidence-based decision-making. However, technology alone cannot resolve human-tiger conflict. Its effectiveness will ultimately depend on the strength of the institutions that support it. Building public confidence requires well-trained forest staff, veterinarians, and rescue teams capable of responding rapidly in conflict situations.

The TOTR underscores a broader national imperative: strengthening the governance of shared landscapes where ecological processes and human livelihoods intersect daily. The initiative signals a shift from viewing tiger conservation solely through the lens of protected areas to recognising the wider mosaic of reserve forests and other lands that now support dispersing tigers.

If executed with the same determination that made Project Tiger a global benchmark, the TOTR could become India's defining conservation initiative of the century proving that people and large carnivores can share space safely.

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

The tiger is the largest cat species in the world. It is both an umbrella species and, when chosen to represent a cause, a flagship species.

- Keystone species: one whose addition to or loss from an ecosystem causes major changes in at least one other species.
- Flagship species: a species chosen to represent an environmental cause, such as an ecosystem needing conservation.

Countries with most tigers (as per the source): India > Russia > Indonesia > Nepal > Thailand.

- **Threats**: habitat loss, climate change, human-wildlife conflict, inbreeding, disease, hunting, grazing, mining, infrastructure development, and tiger farms (captive breeding and sale of big cats).

Subspecies	Range
Bengal tiger	Indian subcontinent
Amur tiger	Amur river region of Russia, China, and North Korea
South China tiger	South central China
Sumatran tiger	Sumatra, Indonesia
Indochinese tiger	Continental South-East Asia
Caspian tiger (extinct)	Turkey through Central and West Asia
Javan tiger (extinct)	Java, Indonesia
Bali tiger (extinct)	Bali, Indonesia

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

Key tiger conservation bodies

- **Project Tiger:** a Centrally Sponsored Scheme of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC), launched in 1973 for in-situ conservation of wild tigers.
- **NTCA** has an overarching supervisory role under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. Tiger Reserves are recognised under Wildlife Protection Act, 1972
- **Global Tiger Forum (GTF):** the only inter-governmental body working exclusively for wild tiger conservation, a forum of 13 tiger range countries.
- **TX2 / GTF goal:** double wild tiger numbers by 2022. India achieved this in 2018, four years ahead of the deadline.
- **CA|TS (Conservation Assured | Tiger Standards):** a WWF initiative offering criteria for tiger sites to check if their management will lead to successful conservation.
- **Global Tiger Initiative (GTI):** launched in 2008 as a global alliance of governments, civil society, and and conservation and scientific communities to save wild tigers from extinction.

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

● The Success and New Frontier

- India's tiger conservation story is regarded as one of the world's most extraordinary wildlife recoveries; since Project Tiger's 1973 launch, the network of protected areas has expanded from nine reserves covering **18,278 sq km to 58 reserves spanning 84,488 sq km**, nearly 2.6% of India's landmass
- India's tiger population has risen from **1,411 in 2006 to 3,682 in 2022**, home to over **70% of the world's wild tigers**; this success has created a new conservation frontier, the growing proportion of tigers living outside protected areas
- According to the **National Tiger Conservation Authority, 35-40% of India's tiger population now lives outside designated Tiger Reserves**, prompting the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change to launch the **Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves (TOTR) initiative**

● Why Tigers Are Dispersing

- **As territorial carnivores requiring extensive home ranges, tigers disperse naturally when core habitats reach saturation; more tigers are moving into human-dominated fringes interwoven with villages, farms, and roads, making interactions with people inevitable**

● The TOTR Initiative

- Its objective is to establish a **scientifically grounded, landscape-based framework for conserving tigers outside protected areas while safeguarding human lives and livelihoods, shifting from reactive crisis management to proactive, science-driven governance**

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

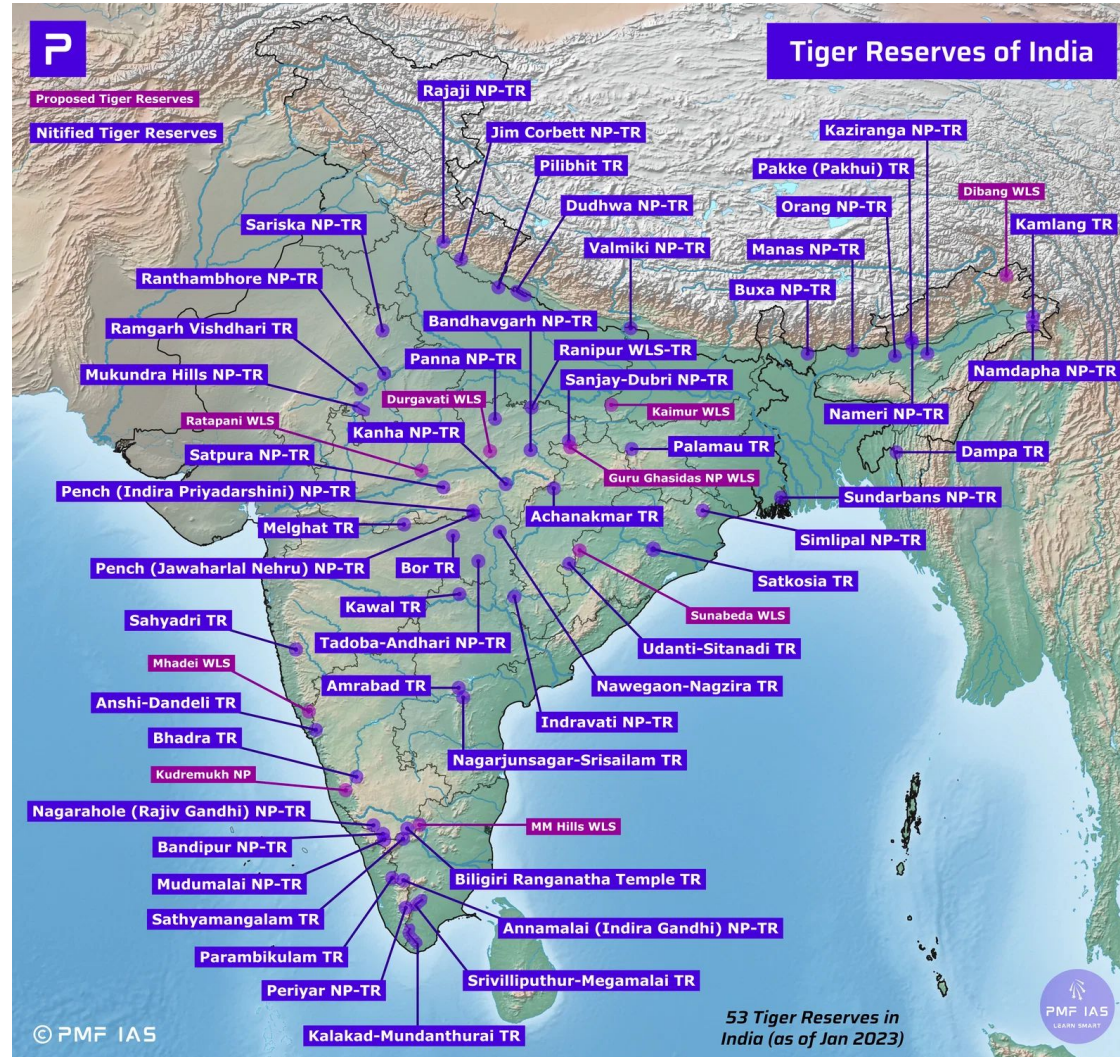
Pillars of the Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves (TOTR) initiative

Conflict reduction: The first pillar focuses on reducing human-tiger conflict incidents in forest divisions where tigers range outside the boundaries of formally notified reserves.

Community coexistence: The second pillar builds mechanisms for local communities to coexist with tigers present in shared, non-reserve landscapes, rather than treating their presence as purely a conservation enforcement problem.

Coverage: The initiative spans 40 forest divisions across nine states, reflecting the geographic spread of India's tiger population beyond reserve boundaries.

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves



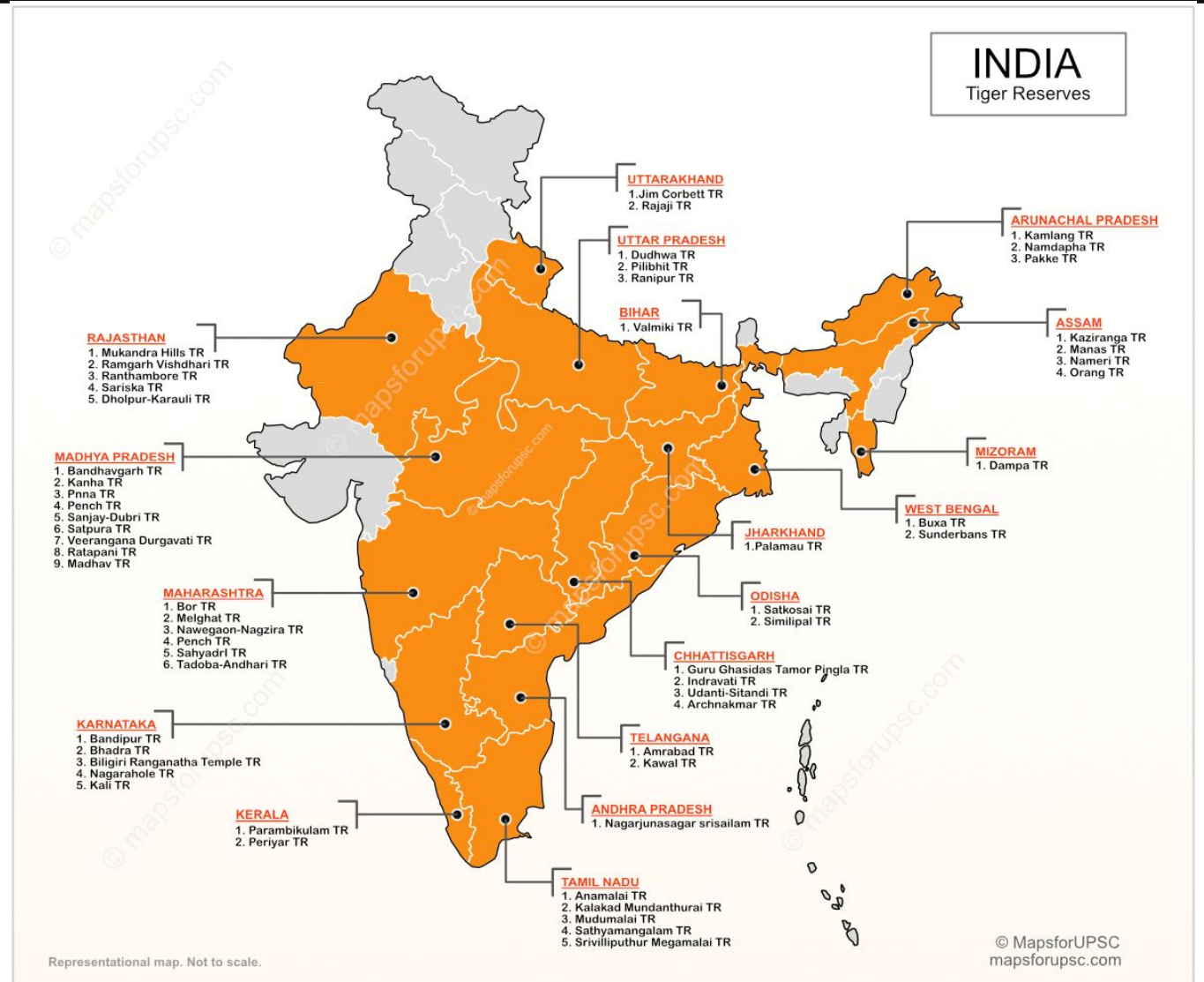
Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

Tiger Reserves of Kerala and South

- Periyar Tiger Reserve is situated in the Cardamom Hills of the Western Ghats and is one of India's oldest Project Tiger reserves. It is famous for the picturesque Periyar Lake, which was formed after the construction of the Mullaperiyar Dam.
- Parambikulam Tiger Reserve : Located on the Kerala–Tamil Nadu border, Parambikulam forms a continuous forest with Anamalai Tiger Reserve in Tamil Nadu, making it one of the most important elephant and tiger corridors in southern India. The reserve is famous for the Kannimara Teak, one of the oldest and largest living teak trees in Asia
- Anamalai Tiger Reserve : Formerly known as the Indira Gandhi Wildlife Sanctuary, Anamalai lies in the Anamalai Hills and shares its western boundary with Parambikulam Tiger Reserve. The reserve includes the famous tourist destination Topslip and is among the best habitats of the Lion-tailed Macaque and Nilgiri Tahr in the Western Ghats.
- Kalakad–Mundanthurai Tiger Reserve (KMTR) : KMTR was the first Tiger Reserve established in Tamil Nadu. It lies within the Agasthyamalai Biosphere Reserve, one of India's richest centres of endemism.
- Mudumalai Tiger Reserve : Mudumalai occupies the northwestern corner of Tamil Nadu and forms part of the famous Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve. It joins seamlessly with Bandipur, Nagarhole and Wayanad Wildlife Sanctuary, creating one of the largest contiguous tiger landscapes in India. The reserve is also noted for the Moyar Valley and important elephant corridors.

Co-Existing With Tigers Outside Reserves

- **Sathyamangalam Tiger Reserve** : Sathyamangalam occupies a unique position because it forms the ecological bridge between the Western Ghats and the Eastern Ghats. It connects Mudumalai and Bandipur in the west with BRT and Cauvery forests in the east, allowing the movement of elephants and tigers across southern India. The forests were once known as the hideout of the sandalwood smuggler Veerappan.
- **Srivilliputhur–Megamalai Tiger Reserve** “ Declared India's 52nd Tiger Reserve, this reserve combines the Srivilliputhur Grizzled Giant Squirrel Sanctuary and the Megamalai Wildlife Sanctuary. It protects important Western Ghats species such as the Grizzled Giant Squirrel, Nilgiri Tahr and Lion-tailed Macaque, while strengthening connectivity with the Periyar landscape.



Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

Beyond national interest: role of ethics and emotions in world politics

History offers numerous examples of ethics shaping international politics. Foreign policy is not merely an exercise in strategic calculation; it is also shaped by moral perceptions and collective emotions, as illustrated by the change in public perception towards the Israel-Palestine conflict.

Dhananjay Tripathi

The language of world politics has become remarkably predictable. Every military strike, diplomatic initiative, economic sanction, or strategic partnership is justified in the name of national interest. Television debates and commentaries have a common vocabulary – power, deterrence, balance of power, strategic autonomy, and security. It almost appears as though International Relations has become an emotionless discipline, focused on power concentration, where morality and ethics have little place. Yet the defining geopolitical crises of recent years tell a very different story.

Influence of Western traditions
International Relations, both as an academic discipline and as a practice of diplomacy, has been largely shaped by Western intellectual traditions, with much of academic research originating in the United States of America. No wonder, famous IR scholar, Stanley Hoffman, in his article, argued that IR is an American Social Science. It is difficult to refute Hoffman's argument because initially the modern international order emerged when European powers dominated much of the world, leaving the Global South with little role in designing the institutions, norms, and rules that continue to govern global politics. However, the discipline itself acquired its modern identity after the Second World War, with the U.S. based scholar, Hans Morgenthau's Realism becoming the dominant framework for understanding international affairs. Realism portrays the international system as anarchic and argues that states, in the absence of a central authority, are compelled to pursue their national interests. Although the theory is far more nuanced than its popular interpretation suggests, public discourse has reduced it to two defining ideas – anarchy and national interest. Over time, Realism travelled from classrooms to newsrooms, becoming the default language through which foreign policy is interpreted. There is much to appreciate in the Realist tradition. It reminds us that power, military capability, and strategic calculations remain central to international politics. However, the dominance of Realism has also encouraged the belief that foreign policy is little more than a rational pursuit of national interest. Ethical considerations are often dismissed as idealistic, while emotions are treated as irrational distractions. Yet certain recent scholarships in International Relations have increasingly challenged this assumption. Scholars such as Veng Crawford have argued that emotions are not the opposite of rationality; rather, they are integral to political judgment. Fear, grief, anger, humiliation, empathy, and pride actively shape how leaders interpret threats, define interests, and respond to crises. Foreign policy, therefore, is not merely an exercise in cold strategic calculation, but also a product of moral perceptions and collective emotions. This dynamic is encapsulated by scholar Brent Steward, who notes that while state leaders make



Moral reckoning: A protest held in solidarity with Palestine, condemning Israel's actions against Gaza, in Bengaluru on September 26, 2023. ALLEN EGENDESE, I.

formal decisions as members of a group, "they do so within a particular (social) context and on that (social) basis".

Question of political legitimacy
The recent U.S.-Iran conflict illustrates this point. Much of the strategic analysis focused on military capabilities, damage assessments, and the future balance of power in West Asia. Comparatively little attention was paid to the emotional and ethical consequences of the conflict. The assassination of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was not only Iran's Supreme Leader but also one of the most influential religious figures in the Shia world, produced consequences that extended far beyond military calculations. Rather than weakening the Iranian state, his death generated an extraordinary wave of national solidarity. A society that had appeared politically divided only months earlier united around a shared sense of loss, nationalism, and religious identity. Crawford's observation that grief and the desire for revenge continue to shape political behaviour long after the battlefield has fallen silent is particularly relevant in this context. Military planners may calculate strategic gains, but societies often respond through memory, identity, and emotion. Therefore, it is important to note that foreign policy must not be judged solely by the actions of a government, but also by how those actions shape and influence global public opinion. The debate surrounding the assassination largely focused on how Washington would engage with a post-Khamenei Iran. Far less attention was devoted to the ethical questions raised by such an operation and its implications for America's moral standing.

The changing international perception of Israel offers another important example. Following the Hamas attacks of October 2023, Israel received widespread sympathy and support across much of the world. Most governments affirmed Israel's right to defend itself. However, as the humanitarian crisis in Gaza deepened, due to mindless aggression shown by the

Israeli army, public opinion began to shift. Large demonstrations across Europe and North America reflected growing concerns over civilian suffering and questioned the proportionality of Israel's military response. In this, governments and societies increasingly spoke in different voices. While many governments continued to emphasise security considerations, public opinion became increasingly influenced by humanitarian concerns. Thus, while military superiority can alter realities on the battlefield, it cannot prevent the erosion of moral legitimacy.

Ethical concerns over globalisation

History offers numerous examples of ethics shaping international politics. Throughout the Cold War, the U.S. consistently presented itself as the defender of democracy, human rights, and individual liberty while portraying Soviet communism as an authoritarian system hostile to political freedom. The post-war liberal international order derived much of its legitimacy not merely from military and economic strength but also from its claim to uphold universal values. Even globalisation was promoted as a project that would bring societies closer together through greater interdependence and cooperation. Although globalisation generated unprecedented economic growth, it failed to bridge the structural inequalities between the Global North and the Global South, leading many to question whether the liberal international order had fulfilled its ethical promises.

The position of Global South

Historically, the Global South has been among the most vocal in rejecting moral considerations into international politics. The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) was not merely a strategy to avoid Cold War rivalries; it represented a normative vision of sovereign equality and a collective call for a more just world order. Contemporary India continues to invoke similar ideas through its emphasis on the Global South and the civilisational

philosophy of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" – the world is one family. Notably, India's international standing has historically rested not only on its growing economic and strategic capabilities but also on its democratic institutions, pluralism, and anti-colonial legacy. During the Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971, for instance, international public opinion gradually shifted in India's favour after the humanitarian catastrophe in East Pakistan became widely known. More recently, India's consistent opposition to cross-border terrorism has enjoyed broad international support because it resonates with widely accepted ethical norms. This moral capital, however, cannot be taken for granted. It must be continuously reinforced through consistent foreign policy choices. For instance, India's relatively restrained response to recent developments in West Asia has generated debate over whether its pursuit of strategic autonomy truly aligns with the ethical principles it frequently projects. Ultimately, India's international standing is built on more than just its market size. It is widely applauded as a vibrant, multicultural nation where democracy has successfully endured.

In conclusion, it is a mistake to interpret International Relations merely as the study of the redistribution of power; it is equally crucial to understand how that power is evaluated. In a world defined by artificial intelligence, digital media, transnational activism, and instantaneous communication, wars are no longer judged solely by governments or strategic analysts. Instead, real-time images of civilian suffering, humanitarian crises, and political violence actively shape international narratives as they unfold. While Realism remains highly relevant for explaining why states pursue power and security, achieving a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of world politics requires us to examine how societies accept, reject, or morally evaluate that power. (Dhananjay Tripathi teaches International Relations at the South Asian University, New Delhi.)

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

Idealism contends that a country's foreign policy should reflect its internal values. In other words, if a government attempts to reduce poverty, defend human rights, or promote religious freedom at home because it believes those positions to be just or moral, then it should strive to do the same abroad. To idealists, that would lead to a more peaceful world in the long term



Let every nation know, whether it wishes us well or ill,
that we shall pay any price, bear any burden, meet any
hardship, support any friend, oppose any foe to assure
the survival and the success of liberty.

- U.S. President John F. Kennedy
1961 Inaugural Address

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

Realism, on the other hand, approaches foreign policy from the perspective of interests as opposed to values. This means realists focus less on another country's domestic policy and more on its foreign policy. In practice, realists prioritize their core interests like security and prosperity in their relationships with foreign countries. Realists tend to focus less on what those governments do within their borders.



A country that demands moral perfection in its foreign policy will achieve neither perfection nor security.

- Fmr. U.S. Secretary of State Henry Kissinger
1994 Foreign Affairs essay

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

	Advantages	Disadvantages
 Idealism	• Promotes values • Supports free societies • Deters bad behavior	• Limitations to influence • Distracts from vital interests • Expensive and time consuming • Unintended consequences
 Realism	• Promotes security and prosperity • Builds influence • Limits costly interventions	• Deprioritizes values • Empowers bad actors

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Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

Case Study: Assassination of Jamal Khashoggi

In October 2018, Saudi agents assassinated Washington Post journalist and U.S. permanent resident Jamal Khashoggi at their consulate in Istanbul. This killing was later linked directly to Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman by U.S. intelligence. President Donald J. Trump faced a decision: His administration could punish the Saudi government for the brazen murder or it could avoid taking significant action. The latter choice would more likely preserve the two countries' cooperation over counterterrorism, regional issues, trade, and investment.

What was the idealist argument for punishing Saudi Arabia?

The assassination of a journalist and U.S. resident violates several principles that the United States stands for. These values include freedom of the press, tolerance of political dissent, and the rule of law.

Refusal to stand strong against such egregious human rights violations could establish a dangerous precedent. Failure to act could lead other countries to believe they can get away with similar acts. Conversely, responding to this incident would send a message to other U.S. partners that it will not tolerate human rights abuses.

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

What was the realist argument for not punishing Saudi Arabia?

The relationship with Saudi Arabia is too important to jeopardize. Saudi Arabia is one of the most influential countries in the Middle East. For decades, Saudi Arabia has been one of the United States' closest partners in the region. Originally focused on oil and security cooperation, today the two countries partner to counter-terrorism and Iran's expanding influence in the region. Additionally, Saudi Arabia is the largest importer of American-made weapons and has invested billions in American companies.

What did Trump choose, and how did it play out?

Realism: President Trump chose not to punish Saudi Arabia, arguing that "if we foolishly cancel [selling them weapons], Russia and China would be the enormous beneficiaries." He also continued to support Saudi Arabia by vetoing a bipartisan Congressional bill that would have ended U.S. support for Saudi Arabia's controversial military campaign in Yemen.

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The assassination of a journalist and U.S. resident violates several principles that the United States stands for. These values include freedom of the press, tolerance of political dissent, and the rule of law.

Refusal to stand strong against such egregious human rights violations could establish a dangerous precedent. Failure to act could lead other countries to believe they can get away with similar acts. Conversely, responding to this incident would send a message to other U.S. partners that it will not tolerate human rights abuses.

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

Case Study: Arab Spring in Libya

In 2011, Libyan dictator Muammar al-Qaddafi threatened to kill civilian protesters en masse after they demanded political, economic, and social reforms during the Arab Spring. President Barack Obama faced a difficult decision: His administration could defend civilian lives by intervening militarily or it could do nothing. The latter choice would avoid embroiling U.S. troops in yet another Middle Eastern conflict following the 2003 invasion of Iraq.

What was the idealist argument for intervening in Libya?

The United States credibly feared that Qaddafi would massacre civilians. By intervening, the United States could save hundreds—if not thousands—of lives. Intervention could lead to the downfall of Qaddafi and the rise of democracy in Libya. Failing to intervene could send other dictators the message that they can brutalize their civilians without fear of reprisal.

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

What was the realist argument for not intervening in Libya?

A seemingly narrow military intervention to protect Libyan citizens could easily escalate into a costly, time-consuming, and dangerous military mission. Such an operation could perilously drain U.S. resources. A humanitarian intervention that becomes a regime-change operation would infuriate Russia and China. This development could cause Moscow and Beijing to oppose similar life-saving missions in the future. Toppling Qaddafi without plans for what comes next could destabilize Libya and further damage U.S. credibility in the Middle East.

What did Obama choose, and how did it play out?

Idealism: President Obama gathered international support for a limited, humanitarian intervention to protect vulnerable Libyan civilians. This intervention, however, quickly evolved into a destabilizing regime-change operation that resulted in Gaddafi's death. This outcome infuriated Russia and China. With the United States and others unwilling to make a lasting commitment to rebuild Libya, the country quickly returned to civil war. President Obama called the failure to plan for Libya's transition the "worst mistake" of his presidency.

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

Case Study: Human Rights Violations in Xinjiang

Since 2017, the Chinese government has detained more than one million Muslims (mostly of the Uyghur ethnic group) in internment facilities. At these shadowy locations, Uyghurs are forced to endure “reeducation,” forced labor, and forced sterilizations. In response, should the United States pressure the Chinese government to stop its human rights abuses or should it prioritize other areas of its relationship with China, such as trade frictions and China’s increasingly assertive foreign policy?

What is the idealist argument for pressuring China to stop its human rights abuses?

The Chinese government’s actions run against U.S. positions on human rights and likely violate international laws around torture, slavery, and genocide. Refusal to stand strong against such egregious human rights violations could establish a dangerous precedent. What will stop other countries from believing they can get away with similar acts? Conversely, responding to this incident would send a message to other U.S. partners that it will not tolerate human rights abuses.

Beyond National Interest: Role of Ethics and Emotions in World Politics

What is the realist argument for not escalating the situation?

The United States has limited power to change the Chinese government's domestic actions. An escalation could prompt China to refuse to work with the United States on regional issues like North Korea. Moreover, escalation would likely impede progress on critical global issues, such as combating climate change.

How has the United States responded?

Realism: In 2021, the United States declared that the Chinese government's actions in Xinjiang amounted to genocide (defined as actions taken with the intent to destroy a specific group of people). The United States joined the European Union in imposing limited sanctions on China. However, the United States refrained from taking any stronger punitive measures.

Will the Govt. Relax Rules on Airport-Airline Ownership?

Will the govt. relax rules on airport-airline ownership?

Has the Adani Group's MoU with Embraer prompted the Centre's rethink on cross-ownership rules?

Jagriti Chandra

The story so far:

Following a request from the Adani Group, the Ministry of Civil Aviation is examining whether to relax cross-ownership restrictions between airport operators and airlines. Officials are preparing a concept note for consultations with the NITI Aayog and other government ministries before any proposal is taken to the Union Cabinet.

What is the government proposing?

The restrictions under review are embedded in airport concession agreements rather than in legislation. The concession agreements for Delhi and Mumbai airports cap aggregate airline ownership in the airport operator at 10%, while those for the Noida International Airport (Jewar) and Navi Mumbai airports

allow up to 26% ownership in an airline. These provisions can also be applied in reverse, effectively restricting airport operators such as Adani from acquiring significant stakes in airlines.

While the Adani Group denied media reports and said it had no interest in entering the airline business, a separate report cited a letter from Adani Airports CEO Arun Bansal stating that Adani Defence and Aerospace "was evaluating participating in the airline business to play a meaningful role in bridging connectivity in tier-2 and tier-3 cities". Government officials have latched on to this rationale, arguing that amending the cross-ownership rules would enable new airline entrants and help break the near-duopoly of IndiGo and the Air India group in the domestic market.

The interest comes at a time when the Adani Group has signed an MoU with Brazilian aircraft manufacturer Embraer

to explore local production of passenger aircraft. Embraer has said that setting up a final assembly line (FAL) in India would depend on securing a substantial aircraft order from the country.

How will concerns be addressed?

The current concession agreements maintain a separation between airport operators and airlines to prevent potential conflicts of interest by ensuring airports remain neutral infrastructure providers and do not favour affiliated carriers in gate allocation, terminal access, airport facilities or other operational decisions.

Government officials say any relaxation of the rules is likely to be accompanied by safeguards to ensure an "arm's length" relationship between airport and airline businesses. Among the measures under consideration are provisions preventing the direct or indirect sharing of commercially sensitive information,

including data relating to slot allocation and airport operations. The proposal is also expected to prohibit common key managerial personnel from holding executive positions in both the airport and airline entities.

The Adani Group is already the largest airport operator in the country with 8 airports in its kitty. It also has a 99.98% stake in maintenance, repair and overhaul company Airworks, has an agreement to acquire a 72.8% stake in pilot training organisation Flight Simulation Technique Centre, ground handling, retail and food and beverage concessions at airports.

How have airlines reacted?

India's two largest airline groups – IndiGo and Air India – have opposed the reported move, arguing that allowing airport operators to own airlines would create conflicts of interest and weaken competition.

IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said there was "no global precedent because it would typically raise a massive conflict of interest, and over a period of time it would go against the interest of consumers."

Air India has expressed similar reservations. A senior executive told *The Hindu* that "vertical consolidation" in aviation is problematic, pointing to the Adani Group's presence across multiple segments of the aviation value chain.

According to the executive, ownership across so many parts of the ecosystem could disadvantage competing airlines and ultimately reduce competition and employment in the sector.

What are some global examples of such cross ownership?

While common ownership between airports and airlines exists in jurisdictions such as Singapore, Qatar and the UAE, these examples largely involve government ownership of both entities.

In Singapore, both Changi Airport Group and Singapore Airlines are ultimately owned by the government, with Temasek Holdings holding a majority stake in Singapore Airlines, while Qatar owns both Hamad International Airport and Qatar Airways, and the government of Dubai owns Dubai Airports and Emirates.

These examples differ from India in that each has one dominant state-backed flag carrier that anchors the hub airport, rather than multiple privately owned domestic carriers competing at privately operated airports. India's proposal, by contrast, would permit common ownership in a competitive market with multiple privately owned airlines, raising concerns over potential conflicts of interest and whether airport operators could accord preferential treatment to affiliated carriers.

Will the Govt. Relax Rules on Airport-Airline Ownership?

● The Proposal Under Review

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● Concerns and Safeguards

○ The current concession agreements maintain separation between airport operators and airlines to prevent conflicts of interest, ensuring airports remain neutral infrastructure providers that don't favour affiliated carriers in gate allocation or terminal access

Thank You